

2.5 Basic Operations In Linux

All tasks can be accomplished in Linux by just using commands. A true Linux geek does not need a GUI at all! Also, the UNIX-based commands are available in all Linux distributions. But the placement of the command in the GUI menu can vary with version and distribution. So its always helpful to know certain basic commands. All you need to do is bring up the terminal (or Console, as it is called) and type in your command: *voila!*, it is executed: no need to search through menus and sub-menus! But this will change when you use another flavour (distributions are sometimes fondly called “flavours”).

To bring up the terminal (where you can manually type in commands), try right-clicking in a blank area on the desktop and look for an option called “terminal window” or “console.” Alternatively, look under the menus for something that says “term,” short for “terminal.” It could be kterm, xterm or just term.

Tip

In Gnome desktop, you can press [Alt] + [F2] to bring up a terminal window. In KDE, K\System\Konsole will take you to the terminal window.

2.5.1 Mounting partitions

By now you have a dual-boot system, and your Windows partitions are still alive. You will have images, documents or videos that you might want to access from Linux. However, when you try to look for the Windows partition, you will not find it! Whatever happened to it, you might ask. Well, you must first “mount” those partitions onto the Linux filesystem. In the computer world, mounting means making accessible to the system a filesystem (or any data). You might ask, while Windows automatically shows you all partitions, why doesn’t Linux?

Basically, the way Windows and Linux deal with files and partitions is different. Windows recognises and clearly demarcates partitions at boot. Linux works differently: unless you mount a partition or a device, the system does not know of the existence of that parti-